



Korobochka (コロボ) 🇺🇸🇯🇵 @cirnosad

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Can the Iranians actually harm US businesses in the Middle East? / 🇺🇸

[Note: This is a war game thread. Nothing written here should be taken as a recommendation but a thought experiment involving the convergence of two subjects: modern service infrastructure and war. Let's hope none of the following happens and the ped*phile psychopath who started this war surrenders before it does.]

Around 24 hours ago, the US bombed a home appliance factory in Iran, killing many of its workers and damaging its equipment. The Iranians vowed revenge and said they would begin targeting US businesses. This is separate to businesses such as banks (already in the target list and already evacuating) and oil companies (already being targeted).

Data Centres as a Target

There are plenty of targets in the region: Data centres belonging to Microsoft, AWS and so on, service companies, start ups, sh*tcoin companies and more. Can the Iranians deliver actual strategic harm on these targets while being limited to indirect fire at the moment? I'm not talking about personnel. As a professional in an adjacent field, that would strike a little too close to home. Besides, most of us are pretty replaceable -- and it would make for terrible headlines and will create enmity. As a bit of a softie, I don't recommend targeting people most of whom have no idea what is going on right now. Can the Iranians harm the US businesses themselves without harming the personnel?

The answer is yes, but it requires an understanding of what makes service businesses valuable today. The US no longer really manufactures anything and these businesses do not either. They consist of completely fungible components and systems, design to be deployed anywhere on this planet (or even the moon if one desired), and integrated into global systems.

Iran could even physically destroy an entire data centre (DC) annihilating everything within it, and these businesses would table a loss, ask for compensation from the state department and treasury and life would go on. The components are designed with intrinsic redundancy. The big customers who use multiple DC wouldn't even skip a beat. It's just fungible components being taken out after all.

In the service industry, the physical devices used to store and process data are secondary in importance to the data stored as well as the ability to access it and process it in a timely and useful manner. Time is money, but data is everything. If the Iranians can cause data loss to a number of businesses, it would be fatal to the United States in multiple ways: Direct loss of business and complete loss of confidence in the "cloud model". *

Redundancy

Iran must take out the data and its availability. Preferably, permanently. Can it do this with missiles, drones and perhaps a nuke or two? Indeed it can, but it needs to keep in mind how sharding works and how to make it fail, as well as the most opportune military attack on a data centre.

Sharding is best explained through the simplest possible redundant code. Let's say I want to send a message to you and I want to make sure that you receive it even if there is a chance that part of it gets lost or corrupted along the way. Let's say I want to say "nine". What if I just repeat myself?

Nine Nine

This actually doesn't help at all. Corrupt one word:

Nine Fine

And it's impossible to tell which of these is the correct word. But repeat it three times:

Nine Nine Nine

You can now corrupt any one word and the majority will still be correct, so you can always recover the message.

Data centres have far more complex schemes, but the horizontally distributed of these can be summarised in the following manners: how many data centres can be destroyed entirely without data loss. That question is going to be different from customer to customer. For a clueless customer that number is going to be 1, but typically their data will be stored in a random server nearby them. They'll have on-site backups anyway. These targets aren't interesting. Iran has to fetch headlines to cause damage: a big customer. These ones will store moderately important data with redundancy 2.

So Iran has to take out two data centres from the same provider at the same time in order to cause some data loss and loss of availability. This is going to be random: a customer has to slice the data between two regional DCs and pay for only a single loss redundancy scheme. There will be many who do so for performance reasons. Why does the attack have to be simultaneous? Because a customer can quickly backup its data from the surviving data centre and resume the business from a different location. So if Iran actually wants to cause strategic harm, it needs a complex mission involving simultaneous strikes on the same DC provider (let's say Microsoft because f**k Copilot and Windows 11).

Can Iran coordinate such a simultaneous attack and pull it off perfectly? I don't know, but it's certainly many orders more complex than a single attack spanning a long amount of time. It has to happen at the same time.

With that established, let us move on: What's the best theoretically way to attack a data centre?



Components of a Data Centre

DCs are far more complex than they seem from a user perspective. They're designed to survive almost any reasonable scenario. Fortunately for Iran, war is not one of them (it is assumed all nations that they are built in are "green" or safe and under a kind of nuclear umbrella).

A nuclear strike can kill a data centre instantly but let's not go so far. It's a waste of a nuke when a few pin pricks should do the job.

Auxiliary (Backup) Power

The most important component to keep in mind is the auxiliary power supply, the on-site diesel generator. Because up time is important these are always on standby mode and fuelled up. This makes them particularly flammable. Strike enough of them and a fire will spread. When it comes to such a large target, fire is your best friend as a mission planner and these things contain all the fuel you need to strengthen that fire. As the generators are damaged the fuel will leak and spread.

Main Distribution Area / Network Room

If the Iranians have done their homework, they would have an internal map of the data centres, meaning it knows where the convergent network equipment meets in what is historically called the main distribution area (MDA). If you can destroy this target, you sever the connection to any of the support team that can move data around, enable fire control countermeasures and otherwise monitor the situation.

Battery Rooms

These are very flammable, because of gullibility, engineers design their DCs to use Lithium ion batteries. These are extremely flammable. If Iran knows where these are, they are a priority target in such a data-decapitation mission.

Main Hall

With the connection to the outside world severed, the still-powered on computers equipment should now be targeted. This is the largest target and a ballistic missile should crack it open, a few fully Shahed drones should then start the fires inside. The equipment is, counter-intuitively, very flammable. There are filters, plastics, foams, special refrigerants and other components that are HIGHLY flammable. Iran just needs to start and kindle the fire with follow up attacks, making sure to use fully fuelled drones with warheads that don't put out fires (i.e. blast type).

HDD/Tape Backup Rooms

If Iran wanted to be particularly nasty it would take out the tape backups. This would render the data loss irrecoverable if redundancy is taken care of. A nightmare for any business.

Electric Power Substation

With the backup power and emergency battery supply on fire, and the main hall a raging inferno, it's quite likely that the fire suppression system would be automatically activated without any intervention from the outside.

Thus, it's time to switch off the lights and power down the sprinklers as well. Iran would target the substation providing the power to the DC to do so. A few shahed-136, a cruise missile or a ballistic missile should do the trick. If this is targeted at night you would see a blue hue in the sky if some onlooker were to film it.

If Iran wanted to be thorough, it would then target any pressurised water reserves used for fire suppression. This would be the final attack on the DC. It's important to keep it on before the fire suppression system activates for the opportunity to start an electric fire (class C) which maximises the damage through melting wires, arcing and what not. Once the power is off, only material will kindle the fire, not electric current.



Now a raging inferno billows in the night in the place where a data centre used to be. Billions of dollars worth of infrastructure and some data is lost forever.

Can this attack be even more damaging?

A bunch of sh*tcoin bros lose their data and headlines damage people's confidence in data centres. People start shelling out money for their own private data centres and the "cloud model" loses money. That's plenty of damage and is aligned with people resisting these large and evil companies. Ultimately, the components within these data centres are mass manufactured and there is plenty of unused capacity. In fact there is more shelved equipment waiting to be powered on than actively powered equipment. People will eventually move on and be lured by the convenience of storing all their data within these large complexes.

Thus there's not much else Iran can do on its own to harm US companies. But, should this war spread to Asia, this damage can be quite permanent.

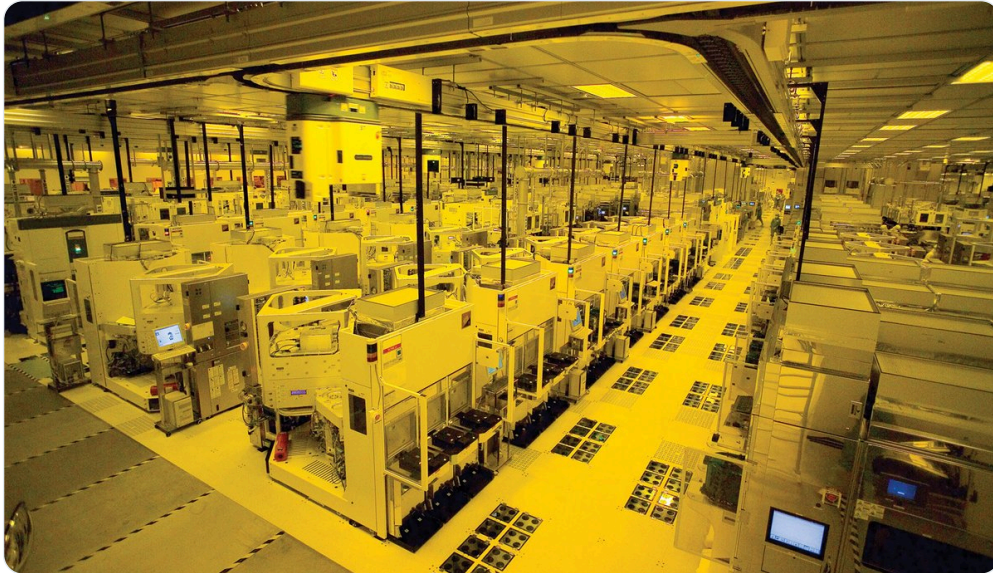
Electronic manufacturing

Within the realms of semiconductor technology, most high-tech nodes today are fabricated in just two countries: Korea and Taiwan. These countries are running out of helium, necessarily in some of the processes (typically ones involving use of plasmas for etching and deposition). Qatar has control of 36% of the export of helium gas and this has been severed by Iran's closure of the Hormuz. But manufacturers can steal it from smaller players.

But what if the Iranians drain so much equipment within CENTCOM that USPACOM becomes an easy target? All those THAAD batteries and Patriot missiles are being practically shoplifted from eastern commanders. Also that 31st Marine Expeditionary Unit...

This is where China and DPRK (North Korea) can step in, seizing South Korea and Taiwan simultaneously! This means no more replacement equipment. Suddenly the loss in hardware becomes equally damaging as the loss in data.

This is quite unlikely at the moment but who knows how the war will evolve?



Conclusion

For the general public: It's probably a good time to make off-site backups and to stop relying on "cloud" infrastructure. Data is everything in the service economy, and being able to keep your services going while these DCs burn to the ground gives you a competitive advantage. Financial companies already account for this. DCs are only used to supplement core business. The majority of businesses don't plan this far though. War seems like an impossibility, yet here we are.

For those observing Iran: Don't underestimate how difficult it is to cause actual damage to US businesses, but also how much damage a few intelligent attacks can cause if coordinated and monitored well.

And for the data centre providers: It is probably a good time to get in touch with the Trumpanzee himself and tell him to stop bringing in civilian targets into play. Otherwise, good luck!

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